SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #13 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A past mistake, a family name, rumors, or a label given in youth can follow us in a community. When people have decided who we are, it can seem pointless to try. We may live down to expectations or withdraw.

What Scripture teaches

Paul was feared by the church after persecuting believers, yet “Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord,” and Saul became Paul. Proverbs says, “A good name is more desirable than great riches,” and a good name can be rebuilt through integrity: “He who walks in integrity walks securely.” Peter says, “Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us.” Trust is rebuilt over time through changed behavior, and God’s view of us is not set by gossip.

> *“A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold”* (Proverbs 22:1).

Also see

> “When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus” (Acts 9:26–27).

> “He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out” (Proverbs 10:9).

> “Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us” (1 Peter 2:12).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Common self-statements

- Everyone already has their opinion of me.
- Nothing I do will change it.
- I will always be that person.
- They will never trust me.
- Why try to be better?
- My reputation is permanent.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that no one will ever change their mind.
- Labeling: Accepting a label as my identity.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing reputation is either good or ruined.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that nothing can change.

Challenging questions

- What is my reputation, and what part is true, false, or outdated?
- Who has seen me change and treated me differently?
- What steps could rebuild trust over time?
- How did Barnabas help Paul, and who could be a Barnabas for me?
- What does God think of me now?
- What will I do consistently this month?

Truth summary

> A reputation can change over time through consistent integrity, and God knows me better than gossip does. I can own what is true, let go of what is not, and build trust one step at a time.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Forgiveness
- Repent
- Humility
- Witness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is my reputation?
- ☐ What is true?
- ☐ Who has seen me change?
- ☐ What steps rebuild trust?
- ☐ Who could vouch for me?
- ☐ What will I do consistently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A good name can be rebuilt.
- ☐ Integrity walks securely.
- ☐ God knows my heart.
- ☐ Barnabas-type friends exist.
- ☐ Trust grows with consistent behavior.
- ☐ I am a new creation.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 22:1
  "A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold."
- ☐ Acts 9:26–27
  "When Saul arrived in Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he was a disciple. Then Barnabas brought him to the apostles and described how Saul had seen the Lord, who spoke to him on the road to Damascus, and how Saul had spoken boldly in that city in the name of Jesus."
- ☐ Proverbs 10:9
  "He who walks in integrity walks securely, but he who perverts his ways will be found out."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Trust rebuilt: Each week, note one act of consistent integrity.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 10:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Walking in integrity, I can rebuild trust one step at a time.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Repent" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Sort the reputation. Write what is true, false, and outdated.
- [ ] Own and repair. Apologize or make amends where needed.
- [ ] Find a Barnabas. Ask a respected person to vouch or walk with you.
- [ ] Be consistent. Do small things reliably.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Trust rebuilt
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be trusted or respected because of my reputation.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I carry a reputation that weighs on me. Help me own what is true, release what is not, and rebuild trust with integrity. Send me a Barnabas, and remind me You know my heart. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.